What in God's Name

By Simon Rich

(Pg 6-7) **VINCE:** NFL?

GOD: *(closing his eyes and massaging his temples . . . . considering)* Packers

VINCE: *(writing it down)* We'll make it happen. What about NASCAR?

GOD: I like Trevor Bayne and David Reutimann. *(then suddenly pointing at Vince)* Hey, how are my numbers?

VINCE: *(removing a pie graph from his briefcase)* Your numbers are fantastic. Eighty-five percent of humans worship you in some way.

GOD: Outstanding. *(Smiling proudly at the chart)* Any problem demographics?

VINCE: Some college kids have doubts, but we think they'll come around. It's just a phase. *(Sighing)* We'll keep working on it.

GOD: *(Smiling)* All right, then. Let's play golf!!

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to Heaven Inc., the grossly mismanaged corporation in the sky. For as long as anyone can remember, the founder and CEO (known in some circles at God) has been phoning it in. And when he does show up at work, it's not to resolve wars or end famines, but to Google himself and read what humans have been blogging about him. Enter Eliza and her mentor, Craig, two underpaid Angels in the lowly Department of Miracles. Eliza has just been promoted from the Prayer Department for her innovative method of coding prayers into priority levels – Level 7 prayers are printed on red paper and routed immediately to God. Everything was rolling along quite nicely . . . until today! What in God's Name by Simon Rich

(Pg 25 – 27) **ELIZA:** Hey, can you explain dreams again?

CRAIG: Sure. Dreams were invented by Angels to test out their beta programs.

ELIZA: *(Embarrassed to be asking another question)* I'm sorry . . . what are beta programs again?

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CRAIG: Oh, they're awesome. They're unreleased pieces of software. In dreams you can try out anything you want. You can break all the rules, consequence free.

ELIZA: Which rules?

CRAIG: Well, a lot of Angels really hate the gravity thing, so you see a bunch of flying programs. What else . . . a lot of teleporting and body morphing and resurrecting the dead.

ELIZA: Don't those dreams screw humans up?

CRAIG: *(Shaking his head)* They're self-erasing. As soon as you wake up, you forget almost everything that happened.

ELIZA: What's your favorite beta program?

CRAIG: It'd have to be Vision Stuffer. That's the one that allows you to visit them. You know, to try to reason with them.

ELIZA: Does that ever work?

CRAIG: *(laughing)* Nah. They usually forget what you told them by morning. And if anything sticks – like an image or a word – the fill in the blanks themselves and write a crazy book about you.

ELIZA: So all of those religions . . .

CRAIG: They're our fault. Do you have any other questions?

ELIZA: Just one. How does he decide? You know, on who gets in?

CRAIG: I don't know. I've always wanted to ask him. But I've never had the guts. *(Craig exits)*

Just then Eliza's computer started to beep as a line of text flashed nightmarishly on the screen.

(Pg 32 – 41) **ELIZA:** *(reading from the screen)* CODE BLACK: Possible tsunami. Potential loss of life. Warn God! *(She looks around the empty office, unsure what to do. Finally she sprints toward the elevators)*

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VINCE: You can't see him right now. He's busy

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ELIZA: But I have a Cod Black. A possible tsunami!

VINCE: You can make an appointment, but there's a two-month wait

ELIZA: I can't wait two months!

VINCE: I don't know what to tell you, honey.

ELIZA: *(Frustrated, Eliza bypasses Vince and shoves open the brass door to God's office)* I'm an Angel. And I'm going to talk to God!

GOD: *(interrupted in the middle of eating his breakfast, looks up)*

ELIZA: *(resolutely but with a quivering voice)* I'm here to tell you about a Code Black? The computer said I should warn you. *(God nods and returns to his breakfast)* I'm sorry for interrupting, but it said there was a potential loss of life. *(God nods and continues eating)* If you're not too busy, I think you should take a look at the tsunami. It seems like a pretty urgent situation.

GOD: I'm sorry, what? . . . . You're right. I'll intervene. *(God picks up the remote control and turns on the television)* You like racing? This is a big one – Bayne's going to his second straight win at Daytona.

TV ANNOUNCER: Bayne and Collins are neck and neck! Collins is making a push a big push! He's three lengths ahead . . . he should win this one easily and . . . Oh no! He's down! His car has flipped end over end! He's escaped the wreckage, but he's on fire . . . wow . . . he really seems to be in a lot of pain. Looks like Trevor Bayne is the winner!

GOD: *(laughing)*

ELIZA: *(cautious, but angry)* Sir, when you said you were going to intervene . . . were you talking about the car race or the tsunami?

GOD: What tsunami? *(Distracted by the TV)* Hey – they're interviewing Bayne!

BAYNE: (lifting the trophy over his head) I just want to thank God for this victory. I couldn't have done it without him.

GOD: *(Clapping his hands)* Did you hear that? Did you hear what he just said?

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ELIZA: *(Forcing a smile)* Yeah. Neat.

GOD: *(Turning off the TV)* Okay. I'm sorry. Where's the earthquake?

ELIZA: It's a tsunami. And I'm not sure where it is – it just said possible. It came in this morning around seven?

GOD: Probably too late to stop it. *(Phone rings and God answers)* Yeah, three o'clock's good. Let's just play nine this time, though. My back's killing me. *(Puts hand over the receiver)* Don't worry about the tsunami. I've got everything taken care of!

ELIZA: *(nodding wearily, she begins to exit then notices a giant stack of red papers, nearly as tall as she was. It was a pile of prayers – all 7s)*

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CRAIG: You want to God with a code? *(clasping his scalp in disbelief)* What were you thinking?

ELIZA: *(hands shaking, she is so angry)* I spent years sorting those prayers. And he didn't even read them. I mean, honestly, what kind of CEO is he? How incompetent can you get?

CRAIG: Look. I know he isn't much of a details guy. But you've got to give the man a little respect. I mean, this whole company was his idea. None of us would even be here without him. He deserves some credit.

ELIZA: I feel sick . . . *(thinking)* You know what? I'm going to go back up there! I'm going to tell him to read those prayers. I spent three years sorting them. He doesn't have to answer them, but the least he can do is read them!

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(Pg 46- 55) NARRATOR: God new that his obsession with the humans was insane. When he first built the universe, after all, he'd never even intended for it to be populated. He'd constructed the earth for one reason and one reason only: to manufacture xenon gas. But God rapidly grew bored with that side of the business. So one day, for amusement, he'd had his staff invent mankind. God

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quickly became preoccupied with the tiny creatures. He began to care about their spots and their wars and their songs and their discoveries. They reminded God of himself.

God thought wistfully about the past. In the beginning, the humans were so easy to please. Give them some fruit, some light, and they'd all be singing his praises. These days nobody said thank you. It made him wonder if his best days were behind him; it made him wonder if it was time to retire.

There was probably a way to fix things, to set the world right. But he was too exhausted to figure it out.

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ELIZA: *(bursting back into God's office)* So you're just going to play golf!

GOD: *(holding his golf bag over his arm; confused)* Do you . . . want to come?

ELIZA: Those prayers (pointing to the huge stack of papers in the corner) I sorted them. It took me years to isolate those level sevens, and you've probably never even looked at them. *(God furrowed his brow, trying to figure out what a #7 was)* Look, I know running Earth is hard. But if you're not going to try to fix things, if you're not going to really devote yourself to it, what's the point of being here? What's the point of even coming to work? Why not just quit? *(A eerie silence settles over the room, then slowly God smiles and begins nodding)*

GOD: You know what? I've been thinking the same thing lately. *(Puts down golf bag and yells through the office door)* If anyone calls, tell them I'm busy. I've got work to do.

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CRAIG: He canceled golf? *(shaking his head in shock and admiration)* I can't believe you just went up there and talked to him.

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ELIZA: It was a scary morning. I mean, it's been five hours and my hands are still shaking! But sometimes, if you really want something, you've got to take risks. You know what I mean? *(Craig's computer bings with an incoming e-mail)*

CRAIG: *(checking his messages)* Hey, Eliza! Check your e-mail!

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GOD: *(Reading the e-mail that he has composed)* Hey gang,

After much consideration I've decided to resign as CEO of Heaven Inc. It's been a fun ride, but part of being successful is knowing when to quit. I want to give a special thanks to Eliza Hunter from the Miracles Department, who really put things into perspective for me. Without her persuasive arguments, I might not have come to this decision:

The earth will be destroyed in a month. I haven't decided how to do it, but it will probably be by fire or by ice. (Demolition Dept: I will make a decision soon, I promise!) The humans of course, will all be killed, so any jobs related to mankind will be eliminated. Don't worry. Even though your services are no longer needed, you will retain full access to our company's facilities. You don't have to turn in your bicycle. Your laundry will still be picked up on alternate Wednesdays. You'll just have more time to enjoy it all.

The planet's been on a downhill slide for centuries and frankly I think it's time we cut our losses. Remember: in the grand scheme of our company, the earth and its creatures are not particularly significant.

I'm pleased to announce that next month I will finally fulfill my lifelong dream of opening a restaurant. I'm calling it Sola, and we're going to specialize in Asian-American fusion.

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CRAIG: Holy shit! Didn't I tell you not to go up there? Look what happened – look what you did!

ELIZA: *(crying)* You're right. It's all my fault. I was just trying to help the humans. I ended up killing all of them. What are we going to do now?

CRAIG: It's going to be okay. Everything's going to be okay.

ELIZA: You need to talk to him . . . You need to talk to God!

CRAIG: Me? I'm just some Angel. I can't walk into his office whenever I feel like it?

ELIZA: *(gives him a look, since she's just done that . . . TWICE)* Come on. We can't let him shut down our department! Please. The entire earth is counting on you

CRAIG: Why me?

ELIZA: Because you're the only Angel good enough to fix this.

CRAIG: *(ramping himself up to the prospect)* Okay . . . Okay. . . I'll go talk to him.

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(Pg 60 – 67) CRAIG: I was thinking . . . maybe you shouldn't give up on the earth just yet.

GOD: *(flicking his wrist dismissively)* That project's a bust. I'm not throwing more good time after bad.

CRAIG: I know things are rough down there. But don't you think you could make it better?

GOD: Look. I'm gonna level with you. With that whole mankind thing? I bit off way more than I could chew. *(motions to the pile of prayers in the corner)* You know, I've never answered a single human prayer? It's not that I haven't tried – I used to spend ten minutes a day on those suckers. I just could never get them to work.

CRAIG: Not even little prayers?

GOD: *(Shaking his head)* Last year this guy prayed for me to fix his stereo antenna. I tried to help him out – ended up striking him in the face with lightning. Two times – bap bap! He exploded.

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CRAIG: You know. I'm pretty good. I bet I could answer some of those prayers for you, if you gave me a chance.

GOD: *(Smirking)* I doubt it.

CRAIG: I'm serious. In the Miracles Department, we deal with these types of things all the time. Things aren't as hopeless as you're making them out to be. I'll show you some of my miracles. I've done hundreds of them. I did two this morning! I helped a guy in Alaska strike oil, I won a girl a stuffed bear at Coney Island .. . .

GOD: How do I know those weren't just coincidences?

CRAIG: *(clenching his fists)* What do I have to do to convince you?

GOD: *(folding his arms and contemplating)* You've gotta call your shot! *(motioning to the pile of prayers in his inbox)* Pick one – any one. It can be the easiest prayer. If you tell me you can solve it – and you do it by next month – I'll keep the earth open. *(God and Craig shake hands and Craig grabs a hand-full of prayers and begins reading aloud)*

CRAIG: Dear God: please give my fat boss a heart attack – Joseph Hickey, 38 , Northern Ireland. – Could be tricky. I could build up plaque in the guy's arteries, but I doubt that would kill him by next month. *(discards this prayer)*

Dear God: Please don't let my hamster die. Andrea Oran 7, St. Louis

NARRATOR: Craig zoomed in on the little girl's bedroom. Her hamster lay in the corner of a fetid cage, taking rapid shallow breaths.

CRAIG: *(Shaking his head)* That hamster's a gonner.

NARRATOR: [He] shuffled through the remaining prayers, anxiety rapidly mounting. Everyone wanted the impossible: A mega Millions jackpot, a perfect SAT score, a pony. Eventually [he] was down to his last prayer. Craig took a deep breath and unfolded it.

CRAIG: Please let me and Laura be together. – Sam Katz, New York City *(with obvious frustration)* Love miracles are impossible. I've tried them – they never work. You

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can't make two humans fall in love with each other. Too many variables. This Laura girl could be married, for all we know. Just because you love someone doesn't mean they'll love you back. Hey – why is this one two pages *(turning to page 2 of the prayer request)* Please let me and Sam be together – Laura – New York. *(Suddenly grinning and confident)* Want to know something? That could work!!

CLOSING

Will Sam and Laura get together? Will Craig and Eliza be able to save the world? Call it divine intervention, call it Karma, heck, call it Bob for all I care . . . . for now the earth is safe!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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